HARVARD AND TRUMP

ANATOMY OF A STANDOFF

As Harvard University wards off an unprecedented assault on its freedom, academic work suffers amidst a 'survival state'. The situation may force Indians aspiring to study in the US to rethink their plans

By **AASHISH KHULLAR**



Harvard University, a global symbol of academic excellence, is now ground zero of a political and cultural standoff with the US government.

Students, faculty, alumni and the administration all currently seem to be dipping in and out of moods of unity, defiance, fear and hope. While they express a range of views, they converge on feeling a greater sense of community and common cause in what they see as a fight for freedom of speech, inquiry and thought.

International students constitute 27 per cent of the student body across Harvard's undergraduate college and 12 graduate schools. Nearly 800 are from India. These students and recent graduates on OPT (Optional Practical Training—a post-graduation work permit linked to the student visa) are in disarray. The legality of their presence in the country hangs in question. The risks include, maximally, deportations, or being forced to transfer schools, both entailing the loss of years of academic effort and research.

For those conducting research in labs, the impact is already being felt as they linger in a 'survival state'. "It is difficult to overestimate the level of waste and disruption this is causing," says a faculty member. "Years of work could vanish. It's not abstract. These are real people, real cures, real consequences," says a young researcher working on potentially life-saving therapies. Another asks, "How can we be expected to apply our hearts and minds to intellectual pursuit and social good if we live in fear of being picked from the street?"

Temporary relief from the court is a sign of hope, but everyone seems to have accepted that this will be a long battle. To some, the situation with the Trump administration comes as no surprise. Over the past few months, Republicans have proposed direct and indirect curbs on institutions of higher education that they see as ideologically misaligned.

Tensions escalated after a letter from the US government, reportedly sent in error on April 11, outlined expanded demands beyond an earlier April 3 communication. The letter asked for an overhaul of university governance structures, elimination of its diversity, equity and inclusion (DEI) initiatives, stricter screening of the views of international students, changes to admission criteria and stricter disciplinary actions for student protests.

Academic freedom is struggling, with consequences for intellectual inquiry, the perception of US higher education and even its soft power

Harvard declined to comply, citing First Amendment protections and academic independence. University president Alan Garber stated, "No government—regardless of which party is in power—should dictate what private universities can teach, whom they can admit and hire, and which areas of study and inquiry they can pursue." In response, the federal government withheld $2.2 billion in research funding, including grants for research in cancer, Alzheimer's, vaccines etc., and threatened to revoke Harvard's tax-exempt status and ability to host international students.

The situation further spiralled when Harvard sued the government over the funding freeze. On May 22, the Department of Homeland Security (DHS) accused the university of "fostering violence, anti-semitism, and coordinating with the Chinese Communist Party", and moved to revoke its SEVP (Student and Exchange Visitor Program) certification—jeopardising the legal status of nearly 7,000 foreign students and thousands on OPT work permits. Harvard challenged the DHS in court and won temporary relief the following day, with further relief granted on May 29. However, on June 4, the Trump administration